

THE MICHAEL THORNE SERIES - BOOK FIVE

The Black Archive

A Psychological Crime Thriller

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READING SAMPLE

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *The Black Archive*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 4,341 words.

PROLOGUE THE SEALED ROOM

* * *

Nolan Peck found the room because the wall was colder than the building plan allowed.

The old Chicago Ledger distribution annex had been empty for eleven years. Its upper floors had already been stripped to concrete, steel and the square pale marks left behind by machinery too heavy to remove carefully. Demolition was scheduled to begin on Monday.

Nolan's job was to make certain no one discovered asbestos, live power or an undocumented void after the excavators arrived.

At 6:42 on Friday evening, the thermal camera showed a vertical band of cold behind the west wall of the former plate-storage room.

Not a pipe.

Too wide.

He checked the plan again.

The wall should have backed onto compacted fill beneath an alley.

Instead, air moved through it.

Nolan set down the camera and placed two fingers against the painted block. The surface carried a faint vibration.

Mechanical.

Regular.

Something was running behind a wall connected to no active electrical circuit.

He called the site manager.

No answer.

He sent a photograph and added one sentence.

UNDOCUMENTED SERVICE SPACE. HOLD DEMOLITION WEST SIDE.

Then he opened the inspection cut.

The first block came free without resistance. It had been mortared only around the face. Behind it stood a steel panel with recessed hinges and no exterior handle.

A black number had been stamped near the top.

00412.

Nolan widened the opening until he could reach the release lever on the other side.

The panel opened inward.

Cold dry air entered the room.

His flashlight found a corridor narrow enough for one person. Steel tracks ran along the floor and disappeared beneath a second door twenty feet away. Six black carrier boxes rested against one wall. Each was the size of a courthouse archive carton and fitted with mechanical locks.

White labels identified the boxes.

PUBLICATION.

CLINICAL.

POLICE.

Three more carried only numbers.

137.

211.

064.

Nolan did not step inside.

He had worked municipal demolition long enough to understand the difference between forgotten property and deliberately sealed property.

The corridor contained no dust.

Someone had used it recently.

He photographed the door, the track and the first six boxes. His phone stored the images locally because the basement had no signal.

A sound came from farther inside.

One metal wheel turning a quarter rotation.

Then stopping.

Nolan backed away.

The outer loading door opened behind him.

He turned.

A woman in a dark city work jacket entered the plate-storage room carrying a hard plastic document case. She was around fifty, perhaps older, with grey hair cut close to the jaw and salt dried along the edges of her boots.

Her badge identified her as a deputy fire marshal.

The name read LENA BRIGGS.

Nolan had met Briggs twice during earlier inspections.

This was not her.

The photograph was correct.

The woman wearing it was not.

"Step away from the opening," she said.

Nolan looked towards the loading door.

A second person stood outside beside a white environmental-services van. Male. Reflective vest. Face turned away.

"I reported the space," Nolan said.

"That is why I am here."

"I reported it four minutes ago."

"The city has a continuous hazard line."

The answer was possible.

It was also prepared.

She opened the document case and displayed an emergency abatement order. The paper carried a real municipal seal, a current case number and an electronic signature belonging to a judge Nolan recognised from permit disputes.

The order authorised immediate removal of unstable archival film from an undocumented sublevel.

It described the room behind him before anyone should have known it existed.

"Nitrate stock can ignite without an external flame," the woman said. "If those boxes contain what the order says, this building is no longer safe."

Nolan read the first page again.

The case number was real.

The address was correct.

The authority existed.

The purpose did not explain how the order had reached the city before his message.

"Who requested it?" he asked.

"Evidence Preservation."

"Which agency?"

"The one that retained jurisdiction."

Not an answer.

Nolan moved his right thumb across the side of his phone and pressed the emergency shortcut without looking down.

No signal.

The woman watched the movement.

"The archive was safer before you photographed it," she said.

Nolan placed the phone on a concrete ledge.

"Then wait for the police."

"The police are one of the reasons it was divided."

The man outside rolled a low transport cart into the room.

Four insulated cases were strapped to it.

They had not arrived to inspect.

They had arrived knowing what they would take.

The woman looked past Nolan into the corridor.

"Which box did you open?"

"None."

"Which one did you touch?"

"None."

"Where is one thirty-seven?"

Nolan glanced at the labelled box before he could prevent himself.

The woman followed his eyes.

"That is the duplicate," she said.

The man entered the corridor and lifted it.

Nolan moved towards the loading door.

The woman did not block him.

She allowed him two steps.

Then the muscles in his left leg stopped obeying.

He struck the floor on one knee.

A sharp pressure remained in the side of his neck.

The woman caught his shoulder before his head reached the concrete.

The gesture was controlled.

Almost careful.

"You are not being removed," she said. "You are being delayed."

Nolan tried to turn his face towards her.

His vision narrowed around the false badge.

"Who are you?"

"Not the custodian."

The man carried box 137 to the cart.

Then 211.

Then 064.

The woman retrieved Nolan's phone and examined the unsent images.

She deleted nothing.

Instead, she placed the phone beside his hand.

"They need to find the room," she said.

The last thing Nolan heard was the mechanical counter behind the wall.

It turned three times: 00411, 00410, 00409.

Then the room became quiet enough for the building to appear empty again.

CHAPTER 1 THREE LINES

* * *

The archive was officially discovered at 8:16 the next morning.

By then, the three numbered boxes were gone.

Elena stood outside the opening in the plate-storage wall while the evidence photographer completed the first fixed-position series.

No one entered until the bomb team, fire marshal and environmental specialist agreed on the order.

The room contained ageing film, magnetic tape, paper and unknown chemical containers. Moving one item before the atmosphere was tested could destroy evidence or injure the person trying to preserve it.

Nolan Peck lay in a hospital twelve blocks away.

He had been found at 7:03 by the site manager, breathing but unresponsive, with a transdermal sedative patch beneath his collar and bruising along one shoulder. His phone contained twenty-seven photographs of the hidden corridor.

The final three showed boxes 137, 211 and 064 in place.

The corridor now held empty rectangles where dust had not settled.

Desai watched the environmental monitor from behind the entry line.

"No explosive vapour," the specialist said. "Humidity is controlled. Temperature fifty-two. Oxygen normal. Nitrate detector is positive but low."

"Can we enter?" Desai asked.

"Two people. Respirators. No powered equipment inside until I inspect the containers."

Elena and the evidence photographer entered first.

The corridor extended thirty-eight feet before opening into a square room beneath the alley. Steel shelving covered three walls. Black archive cases stood in numbered order from 001 to 412, with gaps corresponding to the missing boxes and several older gaps marked by white custody cards.

Nothing was connected to a network.

A mechanical clock controlled ventilation.

A wall telephone had no dial.

The steel floor track ended at a circular carrier table with three active routes.

MEDIA.

CLINICAL.

POLICE.

The words matched the routes beneath the courthouse annex.

The private track had not ended there.

It had led here.

On the central desk lay an open inventory ledger.

The latest handwritten entry was three days old.

TRANSFER 137 - PUBLICATION CUSTODIAN.

TRANSFER 211 - CLINICAL CUSTODIAN.

TRANSFER 064 - POLICE CUSTODIAN.

No recipient signatures appeared.

The next line had been left blank.

Elena did not touch the page.

"Photograph the binding, edges and pressure marks," she said.

The photographer adjusted position.

Desai entered after the environmental specialist approved the floor.

"This is the Black Archive," she said.

"That is the name Vale used."

"Do you see another reasonable description?"

"An offline evidence repository with an unverified owner and an unknown purpose."

Desai looked at her.

"You have been spending time with Wells."

"He would say unknown lawful authority."

The first shelf held photographic negatives in fire-resistant sleeves. The second contained reel-to-reel tape, microcassettes and early digital voice recorders. The third held access-control printouts, body-camera storage cards, evidence-room sign-out sheets and original carbon copies of transfer forms.

Originals.

Not certified copies.

Not scans made after litigation began.

Paper carrying pressure from the pen that created it.

Film with edge markings from the laboratory that developed it.

Recordings stored on the device used at the time.

If authenticated, the archive could answer questions that every later system had made arguable.

It could also expose hundreds of people whose names had been protected for legitimate reasons.

The room was not evidence until each item entered a lawful chain.

And no team in Chicago could inventory four hundred and nine boxes before someone learned what they had found.

Desai read the shelf labels without moving closer.

"We need a special master, victim-privacy protocol and separate filter teams."

"And a sealed warrant extension before we open any box not covered by Vale's route."

"The current warrant covers the tunnel and materials transferred through it."

"Not every therapy record, confidential source file or grand-jury exhibit someone stored here."

Desai nodded.

No argument.

The limitation was not an obstacle to solve.

It was part of preserving the case.

Wells arrived at 8:43 with a paper copy of the original renovation permits.

He remained outside the room.

"The plate-storage wall was closed in 2009," he said.
"Contractor dissolved. Permit reviewer dead. Final inspection signed by a city engineer who says he never entered the basement."

"Fraud?" Desai asked.

"His signature is genuine. He signed a packet containing photographs of a different wall."

A true signature attached to a false conclusion.

The method had changed departments without changing structure.

Wells looked through the opening.

"Any current access?"

"Mechanical only," Elena said. "No network. Nolan's photographs show the missing boxes at 6:46 last night."

"He triggered the discovery. Someone removed them before seven."

"And left everything else."

"Which means the theft was selective."

Elena looked towards the three gaps.

Publication.

Clinical.

Police.

The black card from the courthouse tunnel had named Melissa Kane, Rebecca Chen and Elena Martinez beside the same three symbols.

One package had already reached Melissa.

No package had been reported by Rebecca.

Nothing had reached Elena.

But box 064 had been removed from the room.

"Check every evidence intake under my name since yesterday," she said.

Wells did not ask why.

Desai called the federal duty judge and requested an emergency expansion preserving the room without authorising unrestricted review.

The special master would be selected from outside the district.

A separate team would notify attorneys representing protected survivors before any identifying material was opened.

Michael would not be told the location.

Price would receive notice that potentially responsive evidence existed and that a filter process had begun.

No description of the numbered gaps.

No sequence.

At 9:18, an evidence technician found a narrow drawer beneath the inventory desk.

Inside lay a single black notebook.

The cover carried one letter pressed into the leather.

M.

Elena felt the room pull towards Michael before anyone spoke his name.

She resisted it.

A letter was not authorship.

A notebook in an archive was not proof of who placed it there.

The photographer documented the drawer.

The special master had not yet arrived.

They did not open the notebook.

Wells's phone vibrated.

He read the intake search result.

"A package was logged for you at 7:51 this morning."

"Where?"

"Homicide evidence desk. Hand-delivered by an environmental courier."

"Name?"

"No signature. The desk officer isolated it after recognising the black stock from the Vale alert."

"Number?"

Wells looked at her.

"Sixty-four."

The police line had arrived.

The box had still been stolen.

Whatever was delivered to Elena was not the entire contents.

Someone wanted her to receive a selection.

The rest remained under someone else's control.

CHAPTER 2 THE CLINICAL CUSTODIAN

* * *

Rebecca Chen received box 211 in a room with no patients.

The protected facility had moved her clinical work twice since Michael's arrest. She now used one office for treatment,

one for records review and one for meetings that required counsel, security or both.

The package waited in the third room.

It had not been mailed.

At 8:02, a licensed medical-records courier delivered it under an authentic service order issued through St. Vincent's inactive vendor account. The courier had no knowledge of the contents. His route application showed a routine archival transfer.

The order was real enough to move a box.

The authority behind it was not.

Rebecca stood behind the observation glass while the bomb team opened the outer case.

Inside lay a black document case bearing the number 211.

The case contained twelve microcassettes, four handwritten session notes and a photograph of Rebecca's former office door.

A typed card rested on top.

SECOND CUSTODIAN: CLINICAL SEQUENCE.

Below it:

DO NOT LET LAW ENFORCEMENT HEAR EXPLANATION AFTER ACT.

Rebecca read the sentence twice.

It could be an instruction to protect context.

It could be an instruction to shape causation.

The difference depended on order.

Her attorney stood beside the court-appointed special master, Judge Miriam Solis, retired from the Seventh Circuit and known for refusing to describe privilege as either absolute secrecy or a convenient obstacle.

Solis examined the inventory through the glass.

"Do you recognise the handwriting?" she asked.

"The card is typed."

"The notes."

"Two appear to be mine. I cannot authenticate them at this distance."

"The tapes?"

"I used that model recorder during Michael's first year of treatment."

"Did you retain recordings?"

"No. Sessions were not routinely recorded. On six occasions, Michael consented to audio because he said the gaps made his later recall unreliable. I destroyed the working recordings after completing the notes, consistent with policy."

"Then these may be unauthorised copies."

"Yes."

Or originals that had never been destroyed.

Rebecca did not say the second possibility aloud until the evidence team established serial numbers.

The lead technician read them through the glass.

Three cassettes carried Rebecca's old evidence labels from CPD fitness consultations.

Nine did not.

The unlabelled tapes had been recorded on different stock.

Someone had copied or separately recorded the sessions.

Solis set the first legal boundary.

No investigator would hear the contents until a filter review determined whether the material remained privileged, fell within a patient-danger exception or constituted independent evidence of crime rather than treatment communication.

Rebecca would not conduct that review alone.

She was both therapist and potential witness.

Michael's defence would receive notice and an opportunity to object.

The delay frustrated everyone.

It also prevented the archive from turning therapy into public property merely because someone had stolen it first.

At 10:21, serial comparison established that one cassette came from Rebecca's original recorder.

The tape had not been copied from her destroyed file.

It had been removed before destruction.

A chain-of-custody label on the case carried Michael's handwriting.

DATE: MARCH 14.

PURPOSE: RECALL CONSOLIDATION.

Rebecca remembered the session.

Not every sentence.

The structure.

Michael had arrived after three nights without sleep and described waking in his kitchen with blood beneath one fingernail. Laboratory testing later identified it as his own, from a cut on his palm. He had asked whether the absence of memory meant the action occurred without awareness.

She had said memory and awareness were not the same function.

He had asked the question again in four different forms.

At the time, she thought repetition reflected fear.

Now she understood it may also have been testing.

Which wording produced the interpretation he needed.

Price joined the filter conference by secure video.

Michael did not appear.

Price objected to any review beyond authentication.

"The government cannot use the theft of privileged material to create an exception that did not exist when the communication occurred," he said.

Solis agreed with the principle.

"The government is not asking to listen yet. It is asking to preserve the material and determine what it is."

"Preservation is not neutral when the patient is awaiting trial."

"Neither is destruction."

Price asked whether the clinical delivery had arrived before or after the police delivery.

No one answered.

He repeated the question.

"Sequence affects prejudice," he said.

Rebecca looked at the typed card.

DO NOT LET LAW ENFORCEMENT HEAR EXPLANATION AFTER ACT.

"Did Michael ask you to determine the order?" she said.

Price's expression remained still.

"My client's concern is that isolated statements will be interpreted without clinical context."

"That is not what I asked."

"I cannot disclose privileged consultation."

Solis intervened.

"Then we will not infer the answer."

The conference ended with three actions.

The clinical delivery would be imaged without playing the tapes.

Rebecca's original paper records would be secured by an independent clinical custodian.

Price would identify specific privilege claims by item number, not by refusing the box as a whole.

At noon, Rebecca entered her old notes vault with two witnesses.

Her March 14 session note remained in the bound file.

The paper showed no removal.

The handwriting was hers.

The final paragraph read:

PATIENT SEEKS CERTAINTY THAT ABSENCE OF RECALL
EQUALS ABSENCE OF INTENT. EXPLAINED THAT
DISSOCIATION MAY IMPAIR ENCODING WITHOUT
ELIMINATING PERCEPTION, PLANNING OR CHOICE.

The copy inside the delivery marked 211 carried a different final sentence.

PATIENT'S ACTION MAY PRECEDE CONSOLIDATED
AWARENESS AND SHOULD NOT BE INTERPRETED AS
FULLY VOLITIONAL WITHOUT CONTEXT.

Both pages appeared to carry her handwriting.

Only one was original.

The second had been traced closely enough to survive casual review.

Rebecca compared the pressure beneath the lines.

Her original note indented the page below it.

The archive copy did not.

A reproduction made to look handwritten.

Someone had not merely stolen therapy.

Someone had edited what the therapy meant.

Solis authorised limited playback of the final seven minutes of the March 14 tape for authentication and possible evidence of alteration.

Only Rebecca, Solis, the audio examiner and Michael's privilege attorney attended.

The tape began with Michael's voice.

Calm.

Tired.

More controlled than Rebecca remembered.

"If the body acts before memory forms," he said, "when does responsibility begin?"

Rebecca's recorded voice answered.

"Memory does not determine when the body acts."

"That is not the question."

"It is the part you keep trying to remove."

A pause.

The soft click of Michael opening the pocket watch.

"Then say it in a way a court would understand," he said.

Rebecca felt the room become smaller.

On the tape, she replied:

"A person can fail to remember a choice and still have made it."

No ambiguity.

No exculpatory sentence.

Michael spoke again.

"And if the choice was prepared before the dissociation?"

Rebecca had forgotten that question.

Her recorded answer came without hesitation.

"Then the preparation is evidence of intent, even if later experience fragments."

The tape ended.

The false note had reversed the conclusion.

Rebecca removed the headphones.

Solis did not ask how she felt.

She asked a narrower question.

"Did you ever write the sentence in the archive copy?"

"No."

"Did Michael hear the actual conclusion?"

"Yes."

"Did he ask it in legal language?"

"Yes."

Rebecca looked through the glass at the case marked 211.

Michael had not only used therapy to understand what happened inside him.

He had used it to test how another professional would describe what happened after he was caught.

And someone had prepared a clinical record that made the answer safer.

The question was no longer whether Michael had curated his history.

It was when he began.

CHAPTER 3 THE REMOVAL ORDER

* * *

The Black Archive remained in police custody for six hours and nineteen minutes.

At 2:35 p.m., the environmental monitor detected nitrogen dioxide above the nitrate-film shelf.

The reading was low.

Then it doubled.

The fire marshal ordered everyone out of the inner room.

No one argued.

Ageing cellulose nitrate could decompose without flame, generate heat and ignite surrounding material. The archive had been preserved in controlled air. Opening the room changed that balance.

A hazardous-media specialist from the state archive joined by video and reviewed the sensor curve.

"The film must be moved to cold storage today," she said. "Not tomorrow. Not after the warrant conference. Today."

The order did not cover the paper, audio or access logs.

Only thirty-one film cases required emergency transfer.

The distinction should have protected the rest.

It did not.

At 3:04, a legitimate preservation vendor arrived with two refrigerated evidence vehicles. The company held current state certification, active insurance and an emergency contract with the city.

Every employee passed identification checks.

Every container was weighed empty.

Agents photographed each seal before loading.

Elena watched from the loading dock while the first vehicle received sixteen film cases.

The second received fifteen.

Neither carried the missing numbered boxes.

Neither entered the archive room without an agent.

The process looked controlled because most of it was.

The error occurred before the trucks arrived.

At 3:27, the city procurement system issued an amended destination order.

The first vehicle would proceed to the state cold-storage facility in Aurora.

The second would deliver to a closer temporary vault beneath the Cook County medical archive because the Aurora chamber had reached capacity.

The amendment carried a real contract administrator's credentials.

The administrator was at a dental appointment when it was issued.

Her authentication token had not been stolen.

It had been duplicated from a disaster-recovery terminal used during a flood exercise four years earlier.

No one knew that at 3:27.

They knew only that the temporary vault existed, the address was correct and a county official confirmed by telephone that staff were waiting.

The person who answered the county line worked there.

He had received the same amended order.

A true employee confirming a false destination request embedded inside a real emergency system.

The second vehicle left with a federal escort.

At 3:51, a delivery truck jack-knifed across the lower Wacker entrance, separating the refrigerated vehicle from the rear escort car for ninety-three seconds.

The front escort remained ahead.

Traffic cameras recorded no approach to the evidence vehicle.

No driver exited.

No seal broke.

The convoy continued.

At 4:12, the temporary county vault reported that the truck had not arrived.

The front escort stopped at the address.

The refrigerated vehicle was no longer behind it.

Its GPS continued to transmit from a municipal parking structure two miles east.

Agents found the tracking unit attached beneath an empty maintenance van.

The evidence truck itself was recovered at 5:06 inside a closed produce warehouse near the river.

The driver and evidence technician were alive, bound in the refrigeration compartment with emergency blankets around them.

They had been exposed to sedative gas through the cab ventilation after entering Lower Wacker.

The external seals remained intact.

Inside, the fifteen film cases were gone.

In their place stood three black archive boxes.

137.

211.

064.

The boxes stolen the night before had been placed into the truck during the diversion.

Not returned.

Exchanged.

Elena arrived at the warehouse after the bomb team cleared it.

Wells stood beside the open refrigeration compartment.

"The weight is within four pounds of the original load," he said.

The cases had been packed with lead sheet beneath the archive boxes.

The scale records did not reveal the substitution.

"Why exchange them?" Elena asked.

"To put these three inside our chain."

"After selecting their contents."

"Yes."

The boxes were lighter than Nolan Peck's photographs suggested.

Each had been opened.

Each contained evidence.

Not everything.

Box 137 held twelve original photographs, including the image Melissa had already received, but the negative sleeves were empty.

Box 211 held the tapes and false notes delivered to Rebecca, but three cassette positions were vacant.

Box 064 held police access logs from Curator-related dates, but the original badge-reader memory card had been removed.

Someone had returned the explanations.

They kept the sources that could authenticate or contradict them.

The stolen nitrate-film cases contained original images from James Thorne's studio, Ascension facilities and early Curator scenes.

Their loss was not random hazardous-material theft.

The emergency had been used to replace selected evidence while removing the oldest visual originals.

Wells handed Elena a personnel image from the produce warehouse camera.

A man in a preservation-vendor jacket had entered through the side door at 3:44.

He was sixty-three, broad through the shoulders and bald except for a white strip above each ear.

The face matched a retired Chicago Police Department employee.

Elliot Sayer.

Twenty-eight years in Evidence and Recovered Property.

Supervisor of emergency transfers from 2003 to 2015.

Worked under Captain James Morrison during two internal corruption inquiries.

Signed the release sheet when Michael Thorne's service weapon was removed for testing after Gabriel Shaw.

Signed it again when the weapon returned.

"Current address?" Elena asked.

"Apartment in Bridgeport. Empty. Neighbour says he left yesterday with two hard cases."

"Family?"

"Widower. One daughter in Oregon. No recent contact."

"Criminal history?"

"None. Twelve commendations for evidence recovery after fires and floods."

A man trained to remove the right objects during chaos.

Not a person selected by accident.

Desai entered carrying the first forensic report from the amended destination order.

"The duplicated authentication token came from a 2022 disaster exercise," she said. "The exercise coordinator was Elliot Sayer."

"He kept a working copy for four years."

"Or someone kept it with his knowledge."

Elena looked at the three returned boxes.

Sayer could have destroyed them.

Instead, he placed them into official custody after removing specific originals.

The act contained two purposes.

Preserve a narrative.

Control what could challenge it.

"Who authorised Sayer?" Desai asked.

Wells answered with a question.

"Who knew publication, clinical explanation and police logs would need to arrive in that order?"

No one said Michael's name immediately.

They did not need to.

At 5:41, Price filed an emergency motion requesting confirmation that no privileged clinical material had been commingled with police evidence during transport.

The motion described boxes 137, 211 and 064 by number.

Those numbers had not been disclosed to the defence.

Continue reading

You have reached the end of this reading sample from The Black Archive. The complete work continues beyond this excerpt.

The Michael Thorne Series - Book Five